launched a campaign to crush what they thought were scattered remnants of the movement. In November 1995, Operation Romeo was carried out against the radicals' main stronghold in Rolpa. In what was to become his last interview before going underground, Bhattarai told the weekly Nepalese newspaper *The Independent* in December,

> Under this armed police operation around 1,500 policemen including a special trained commando force sent from Kathmandu have been deployed to let loose a reign of terror against the poor peasants of that rugged mountain district [Rolpa] in western Nepal. So far about 1,000 people have been arrested, of whom about 300 are kept in police custody or sent to jails under fictitious charges while the rest have been released on bail after severe torture.[1]

Shortly after the interview, Bhattarai left Kathmandu to link up with his friend Prachanda. The Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist) (CPN-M) was born, although the exact date of its formation is still a bit of a mystery. It could have been set up as early as late 1994, before the police operations began in the west, and whatever the name of the organization, a well-organized, underground Maoist movement was already in place well before the attacks of February 1996. Resorting to armed struggle was also, according to Prachanda, a 'decisive attack on revisionism which had been inflicting [the] Nepalese Communist movement. In other words, this great process started burning the heap of revisionist filth. The reaffirmation of the truth of the ideology of the international proletariat in the form of Marxism-Leninism-Maoism has been proved practically from February 13th.'[2]

It is clear that the actions taken on that day had been meticulously planned for maximum impact and symbolism. The local police were organs of the oppressive state, banks and moneylenders exploited the poor, and, in the words of Prachanda, the attack on the Pepsi-Cola factory symbolized the 'commitment to free the people from the exploitation of [the] comprador bourgeois class which directly represents the imperialists'.[3] The struggle, Prachanda stated, 'started spreading throughout the country from February 14th onwards … [and] actions against the feudals, goons in different parts of the country, especially against those from the rural areas started taking place continuously. The sky of Nepal reverberated with slogans such as "Long Live Maoism!", "Long live people's war!", "Long live New Democracy."'[4]